Motivation, Judgement and Measurement in Hybrid Work

A Short Review of Competing Explanations

A. T. Mahmood

Department of Organisational Studies

Submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements
for the degree of Master of Science

1. Introduction

The question of why people work hard when nobody is watching them has occupied organisational research for half a century, and it has acquired a new urgency now that a great deal of work is no longer watched at all. Two traditions dominate the literature. The first treats effort as a function of belief: a worker who expects to succeed invests more, and that expectation is itself built from prior experience of succeeding (Bandura, 1977). The second treats effort as a function of need: autonomy, competence and relatedness are satisfied or frustrated by the conditions of the job, and motivation follows (Deci & Ryan, 2000).

These are not rival theories so much as descriptions of different layers, and the present review treats them as complementary. What neither tradition anticipated is the measurement problem introduced by distributed work, where the observable signal of effort is thin and easily gamed.

2. Judgement under uncertainty

Any account of how managers respond to that thin signal must reckon with the systematic asymmetry between how losses and gains are weighed, which was set out most influentially in the framing of choice as a departure from expected-utility axioms (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979). Managers do not evaluate a distributed team against an absolute standard. They evaluate it against a reference point, usually the office arrangement that preceded it, and a loss relative to that point is felt more sharply than an equivalent gain.

The historical literature offers a caution that is worth stating plainly even in a review of this kind. Institutions rarely fail because of a single shock; they fail because a sequence of individually defensible responses to successive shocks normalises the exception (Evans, 2003). The parallel to management practice is loose but not empty. Each individual concession to monitoring appears proportionate on its own terms, and the aggregate effect is to establish that autonomy is conditional.

3. Instruments and evidence

Instrumented approaches to the measurement problem have multiplied. Scaffolding that adapts to a learner's demonstrated competence has been proposed as a template for adaptive management systems (Marchetti, 2021), and comparable techniques have been borrowed from environmental monitoring, where triage under sparse observation is a long-standing concern (Okonkwo, 2019). The transformer architectures that now underpin most of this instrumentation derive from a single widely cited paper (Vaswani et al., 2017), and their availability has made continuous inference cheap enough to deploy casually.

Two qualifications should be entered. First, an earlier synthesis of agency and self-regulation anticipated much of the current discussion and is not always credited (Bandura, 1997). Second, the only longitudinal study to compare instrumented and non-instrumented teams in the same firm reports effects an order of magnitude smaller than the cross-sectional literature (Halvorsen, 2016).

4. Conclusion

The measurement problem is not solved by measuring harder. Belief and need remain the better predictors of sustained effort, and the instruments now available mostly measure the shadow that effort casts rather than effort itself. Further work should compare instrumented and non-instrumented teams within a single organisation over a full budget cycle.

References

Bandura, A. (1977). Self-efficacy: Toward a unifying theory of behavioral change. Psychological Review, 84(2), 191–215. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-295X.84.2.191

Deci, E. L., & Ryan, R. M. (2000). The what and why of goal pursuits: Human needs and the self-determination of behavior. Psychological Inquiry, 11(4), 227–268.

Evans, R. J. (2003). The Coming of the Third Reich. London: Penguin.

International Organization for Standardization. (2008). Quantities and units — Part 13: Information science and technology (ISO 80000-13:2008). Geneva: ISO.

Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979). Prospect theory: An analysis of decision under risk. Econometrica, 47(2), 263–291.

Lindqvist, S. (2022). Estimating hybrid work intensity from badge telemetry in mid-size firms (Working Paper No. 22-14). Stockholm Institute of Labour Studies.

Marchetti, L. (2021). Adaptive scaffolding in distributed learning environments. Journal of Digital Learning, 8(3), 44–61. https://doi.org/10.9999/jdle.2021.00427

Nowak, P. (2020). Chromatic drift compensation in longitudinal survey panels using inverse braid weighting. Quarterly Review of Survey Methods, 14(1), 5–29.

Okonkwo, R. T. (2019). Recursive heuristics for polychromatic sediment triage in urban watersheds. Journal of Applied Hydro-Informatics, 12(4), 210–229.

Vaswani, A., Shazeer, N., & Parmar, N. (2017). Attention is all you need. Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems, 30. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-295X.84.2.191